

Honor Winter

Religion, Technology and Consumerism in *God* by Elsa Von Freytag-Loringhoven

Elsa Von Freytag-Loringhoven's *God* is an artwork based neither in representation nor aesthetics. *God* blatantly calls into question traditional values and expectations held for the work of art in the 20th century, with her appropriative use of discarded materials and products. In doing so, Loringhoven aligns herself with the Dada art movement, most known for exposing the absurdity of life and their rejection of societal structures they viewed as falsely constructed. Her work questions the function of authority in society, while also, in *God* especially, hoping to enlighten viewers to the omnipresent, yet concealed, impact of technology and consumerism on society.

Loringhoven's *God* takes an ordinary metal pipe, showing signs of rust and heavy use, and mounts it onto a wooden base, signifying it is worthy of a platform. The tube lacks any major embellishment: no paint nor decoration. Instead, it is gritty, looking almost too dirty to touch. Loringhoven makes little attempt to beautify the object and appeal to art's expected aesthetic value. Also noteworthy is that this pipe was not made by the Baroness, but found.¹ The plumbing product had originally been made with no artistic intentions in mind, it was simply constructed to fulfill a role. While this may seem an unusual choice for the subject of an artwork, it is typical of Loringhoven's work. While walking down a NYC street one day, "she came across a small, discarded piece of metal...she approached it and picked it up. At that moment, she was struck by inspiration and anointed the small metal ring as a piece of art, entitling it 'Enduring

¹ "Baroness Freytag-Loringhoven Art, Bio, Ideas," The Art Story, accessed November 22, 2024, <https://www.theartstory.org/artist/von-freytag-loringhoven-elsa/>. "attribution is likely from the fact that the Baroness ripped out the clogged pipe in Schamberg's studio and attached it (perhaps with Schamberg's assistance) to the miter box."

Ornament.”² Her awe at finding the object and the work’s name imply its importance to her. The word “enduring” references something of long-lasting quality, likely the durable nature of machine-made goods. “Ornament” implies something that “lends grace, beauty, or festivity” or one “whose virtues or graces add luster to a place or society.”³ It’s evident that the Baroness sees found objects as holding great value, having an impact on society through their beauty and long-lasting nature. Irene Gammel writes how “the Baroness appropriated an every-day object as art, challenging traditional Western art concepts, which equated art with an object both unique and aesthetic.”⁴ Though the Baroness finds them highly valuable, most would overlook these consumer products as something of little value. A plumbing pipe is not often associated with the term “art,” it is a product we identify with a specific purpose. If a pipe were to lose its function, one would likely discard it. In *God*, however, the pipe is not only given a sacred title but also placed on a wooden pedestal. Comparing it to religion and art, the pipe is linked to aesthetics. Linking plumbing with beauty, Loringhoven radically challenges viewers to reconstitute traditional conceptions of beauty.

Loringhoven’s reasoning for this stems from her love of New York City, where she lived in the 1910s. In the city, she “voraciously mined” its way of life, through a focus on its “consumer culture, which offered tins, celluloids, and advertisements.”⁵ She was interested in the city and how it was characterized not by its architecture, landmarks, nature, etc...but through its

² 1. Sofia Schartner and Fran Bidwell, “The Mama of Dada: Elsa von Freytag-Loringhoven, the Original Mastermind behind Fountain, 1917,” *Journal of Student Research* 10, no. 1 (March 31, 2021), <https://doi.org/10.47611/jsrhrs.v10i1.1387>, 2.

³ “Ornament Definition & Meaning,” Merriam-Webster, accessed November 22, 2024, <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/ornament#:~:text=of%20%20noun-,or%C2%B7%E2%80%8Bna%C2%B7%E2%80%8Bment%20%CB%88%C8%AFr%2Dn%C9%99%2Dm%C9%99nt,addition%20of%20something%20that%20beautifies.>

⁴ Irene Gammel, *Baroness Elsa: Gender, Dada, and Everyday Modernity* (Cambridge, Mass: MIT Press, 2002), 160.

⁵ Gammel, *Baroness Elsa*, 182-183.

proliferation of products and consumer goods. New York's economy and society was centered around consumerism.⁶ By the turn of the century, New York had rapidly transformed, and Loringhoven had witnessed "the construction of skyscrapers, subways, and streets that continually changed the face of the city."⁷ Shopping, consumerism and marketing overwhelmed the city's inhabitants.⁸ Living in a city of constant change and seeing the prevalence of consumerism, Loringhoven looked for a way to encapsulate this within her work. As Irene Gammel writes, the Baroness was like "an archivist collecting New York City's contemporary consumer objects, its smells, its junk..."⁹ Loringhoven believed that these objects, though often overlooked and discarded, are part of what defines a city. Like the work of Berenice Abbott and the *Changing New York* project, Loringhoven attempts to encapsulate the city but not through photographic documentation of the city's buildings and shifting architectural landscape, but the city's consumer goods, looking at the city through what it consumes, buys, uses.¹⁰ Discarded objects have never been of particularly high importance, but by taking "objects found in the gutters of New York and mirroring back New York's gutter beauty," she demonstrates that these objects show, in a grotesque way, the beauty of a city.

Extending her art beyond canvas and sculpture, Loringhoven also adorned both "herself and her living spaces with these found objects, making herself into a "living museum body." Incorporating these products into all aspects of her life, she identifies these consumerist objects not only with the city, but with herself. She wanted to be seen, through wearing them, as a "product" of the city, encapsulating it and the consumerist lifestyle within herself. In her poem

⁶ Joseph Gornail, "NYC 1910-1915: Skyscrapers Emerge & Social Reforms Begin," History 101 NYC, accessed November 22, 2024, <https://www.history101.nyc/new-york-city-from-1910-to-1915>.

⁷ Gammel, *Baroness Elsa*, 183.

⁸ Gornail, "NYC 1910-1915."

⁹ Gammel, *Baroness Elsa*, 184-5.

¹⁰ Berenice Abbott, *Changing New York*, 1935-39.

Subjoyride, the viewer “traverse[s] a museum city of readymades and objects trouvés.”¹¹ (10) To her, the city is more and more becoming a site for consumerism, so much so, that the city, and its people are defined by its products. However, the omnipotent status of consumerism is almost never acknowledged. In a 1965 interview, Marcel Duchamp writes: “the only works of art America has given are her plumbing and her bridges.” While this may seem sarcastic, perhaps Duchamp has a point. Though these things may seem mundane, they define our everyday lives, having a hold over us through their much needed functions. In *Subjoyride*, Loringhoven mashes “objects, brand names and landmarks” together, drawing attention to the city’s “very construction.”¹² She appropriates “consumer product and advertisement slogans” with the intention of crafting aesthetically the sensation of existing in the modern world.¹³ The modern world has become defined not through what it once was: architecture, people, streets, landmarks, but instead through its products. With both her poetry and works like *God*, it is impossible for the viewer to ignore, as they do everyday, what is constituting their reality: goods. Loringhoven’s adornment of products on her person perfectly encapsulates her contemporary New York: society’s consumption has become an obsession, to the point where products begin to define our identities.

By taking a piece of metal and naming it *God*, Loringhoven associates a discarded, valueless object with power and authority. These objects, through her title, are reasserted as sacred. The title *God* draws its power from the authority traditionally wielded by religion. For centuries, art that dealt with religion, like icon paintings, were considered godly themselves because of their supposed ability to connect viewers to these divine beings. For such a reason,

¹¹ Elsa von Freytag-Loringhoven, Irene Gammel, and Suzanne Zelazo, *Body Sweats: The Uncensored Writings of Elsa von Freytag-Loringhoven* (Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, 2016), 10.

¹² Gammel, *Body Sweats*, 9.

¹³ Gammel, *Body Sweats*, 9.

the expectation with creating these works was to evoke reverence with viewers. In contrast to other works of art that craft images of God, which usually present viewers with a stately, all powerful man, what's presented here is a scatological appliance.

In line with dadaist philosophy, Loringhoven uses the title *God* to allude to, but also question religion's power and authority. *God* is quite similar to dadaist Hugo Ball's *Karawane* performance in this way.¹⁴ In *Karawane*, Ball recites a series of gibberish phrases, reminiscent of a religious chant, while wearing a lobster costume, that mocks the attire of clergymen. Ball, here, critiques the seemingly omnipotent power religion holds over society, and highlights how truly nonsensical it is. *God* similarly pokes fun at religion, by presenting viewers with an unexpected image. Here, God is shown to be nothing but a plumbing structure. The metal material is also dirty and scratched. By doing so, Loringhoven critiques the high value we place on religion, substituting a "holy image" for plumbing materials, defying the reverence society gives to God. Though her work fits well within the Dadaist's aims, it was given only minor attention, mainly due to the fact that she was a woman. Tristan Tzara in his Dada manifesto, writes the line: "everybody does it in the form of crystalbluffmadonna, monetary system, pharmaceutical product, bare leg advertising the ardent sterile spring [season]," critiquing the false comfort we find in things such as "religion, money, technology..."¹⁵ Loringhoven's *God* deals specifically with the falsehoods of religion in a very dada fashion, however her work is never at the center of discussion on the Dada movement. Yet, her work inspired many other artists, most notably Marcel Duchamp. She is argued to be the original creator of the "readymade," a title usually given to Duchamp, having created "Enduring Ornament" a year prior to Duchamp's first

¹⁴ Hugo Ball, *Karawane*, Cabaret Voltaire, Zurich, 1916.

¹⁵ "Tristan Tzara, 'Dada Manifesto 1918,'" *Modernism*, November 4, 2013, 153–54, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315833125-33>.

readymade.¹⁶ Obviously her work greatly impacted the Dada community and excelled in creating absurd art that questioned established systems within society, but it has not had the attention it deserves.

As Walter Benjamin writes in *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction*, art is never “entirely separated from its ritual function.”¹⁷ While for centuries art was tied to religious functions, the rise of mechanical reproduction shifted this reverence elsewhere. With Loringhoven’s *God*, she demonstrates this religious reverence has shifted to technology. Through alluding to the mystical, omnipotent figure in her title, yet presenting viewers with a mass-produced object, she reveals how in the modern age, society no longer revolves around religion, but instead technology. Loringhoven is asking viewers to examine how objects have become, unbeknownst to them, the center of their lives, they are everywhere and used endlessly. We rely on technology for everything. For example, modern plumbing, which *God* alludes to, was invented in the early 1900s.¹⁸ While we may see this object and take it for granted, even discarding it, it does provide a much needed purpose. Society’s reliance on technology gives it a God-like quality, they worship it, however never acknowledging its role.

The message of Loringhoven’s *God* is no less relevant to 21st century society, in fact, it may be even more relevant. Increasingly, we are in an age where technology and consumerism are present in every aspect of our lives. Loringhoven’s work acknowledges technology’s God-like quality, in a way that society (still) does not. The consumerism of the 20th century has

¹⁶ Gammel, *Baroness Elsa*, 161.

¹⁷ Benjamin, Walter. *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction*, 1936, IV.

¹⁸ Nathan Vogeles, “A Brief History of Modern Plumbing,” Cates Heating And Cooling, September 20, 2022, <https://catesheatingandcooling.com/blog/a-brief-history-of-modern-plumbing/#:~:text=Modern%20Plumbing%3A%20The%201900s%20to%20Today&text=A%20man%20named%20John%20McAdam,very%20primitive%20and%20dangerous%20profession.>

grown extensively, with the birth of online shopping, fast fashion and the internet. Our products, more than ever, are what we use to define ourselves. Through our curated purchasing of mass-produced goods, we seek the validation of others and hope to be seen somehow as unique. Loringhoven's *God* confronts these comforts we find in religion, technology and products, in a dadaist fashion, pulling from absurdism to craft a multi-faceted commentary on the way we live our lives.



Elsa von Freytag-Loringhoven, *God*, 1917, Philadelphia Museum of Art.

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